



I AM NATURE

Journey Back to Self: The Rebalancing Meal Plan

4 Phases · Whole Food · Herbal Rituals Included

This is not a diet. It is a return.



Rooted in African tradition. Grounded in lived experience.

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Where this began

A return, not a reset

This programme was never designed as a weight loss plan. It began as a spiritual decision: to change what I was putting into my body as an act of coming back to myself. The weight loss, when it came, was incidental. An unexpected gift from a body that had been waiting for me to listen.

What you are holding is that protocol, written down. Four weeks. Four phases. Simple, affordable, whole food, rooted in the rhythms that worked for me and grounded in the wisdom of the plants that guided the way.

Work through it at your own pace. Trust what your body tells you. This is not about perfection. It is about consistency, and the willingness to show up for yourself one meal, one morning ritual, one day at a time.

Rooted in truth. Guided by experience.

Nomzamo Mbelebele

Understanding the process

How this system works

This is a two-phase process. The first phase asks you to simplify. The second asks you to listen.

Phase 1 The Reset (30 days) You simplify. You remove noise. You allow the body to stabilise. One meal. Real food. Morning rituals. Consistent movement. Nothing more.

Phase 2 The Return (ongoing) You reintroduce life. You eat with awareness. You maintain without force. The discipline becomes natural because the body now participates in the decision.

Some bodies shift quickly. Others take longer. If after 30 days you have not yet reached your desired result, you simply continue Phase 1. For me, the full shift took approximately three months. There is no failure here. There is only the pace that is true for your body.

Important

Please read before you begin

This programme is a whole food eating plan drawn from personal experience. It is not a medical diet, a treatment protocol, or a substitute for professional nutritional guidance. Individual results vary. If you have a diagnosed health condition, are pregnant or breastfeeding, or are under medical supervision, please consult your healthcare provider before beginning this or any other dietary programme. Nomzamo Mbelebele is not a registered dietitian or medical practitioner.

A note on movement

Because the weight loss was never the goal, I was not prepared for what significant change can do to the skin. If I could go back, I would tell myself: move your body. Not to burn calories, that was never the point. But to keep the skin firm and elastic as the body changes. Walking, stretching, dancing, whatever feels natural to you. Something that gets the blood moving and keeps the muscles engaged beneath the skin.

You do not need a gym. You do not need a programme. You need consistency. Even 20 to 30 minutes of intentional movement each day makes a real difference. Start from the first week, not once you notice the problem. I am telling you this because I wish someone had told me.

Let go of expectations. Enjoy the journey. Pay attention to your thoughts, your intuition, and your dreams, as well as what your body is telling you along the way.

You are becoming. This is the beginning of your journey back to self.

YOU ARE NATURE.

What you are choosing and why

Core food groups

Each ingredient was chosen with intention. The grid below gives you a brief note on what each one offers the body, and where relevant, what it carries in tradition. You are not required to eat everything listed. These are your options. All proteins, starches, and vegetables are freely interchangeable within the formula: one protein, one starch, two vegetables, and a healthy fat. Choose what your body is asking for.

Proteins

Ingredient	What it offers
Eggs	Complete protein with all essential amino acids. Rebuilds tissue, supports brain function, and sustains energy without spiking blood sugar. In many African traditions, eggs represent new beginning and potential held in perfect form.
Chicken	Lean and easily digestible. Supports muscle repair and immune function. Light enough for the body to process efficiently during a reset.
Fish	Rich in omega-3 fatty acids that reduce inflammation, support the brain, and nourish the skin from within. The ocean's oldest medicine.
Lentils	High in plant protein, iron, and soluble fibre. Feeds the gut, steadies blood sugar, and is one of the most complete plant foods available. Humble, affordable, and quietly powerful.
Beans	Slow-releasing energy, rich in fibre and minerals. Keeps the body full and the gut moving. A staple across African kitchens for good reason.
Soya mince	A plant-based protein option for those reducing meat. Versatile and satisfying when well seasoned.
Red meat (optional)	Listen to your body. If it asks for it, honour that. Choose quality over quantity.

Starches

Ingredient	What it offers
Sweet potato	Rich in beta-carotene, Vitamin C, and potassium. Feeds the gut lining and steadies blood sugar more gently than refined starches. In traditional practice, root vegetables are considered grounding foods, connecting the body to the earth.
Sorghum	An ancient African grain, naturally gluten-free and high in antioxidants. Sustains energy, supports the gut, and carries the memory of this continent in every grain. Cook with a 1:3 ratio of grain to water, simmering for 45 to 60 minutes until soft. For maximum benefit, ferment sorghum for three days before cooking: rinse, cover with double the volume of water, and leave at room temperature for three days, changing the water once daily. Fermentation breaks down phytic acid, increases the bioavailability of iron, zinc, and B vitamins,

	improves digestibility, and develops natural probiotics in the grain.
Amadumbe	Indigenous to southern Africa. High in fibre, potassium, and complex carbohydrates. Easier on the digestive system than many other starches. Peel, boil in salted water for 30 to 40 minutes until tender. A food that has fed this land for centuries.

Vegetables

Prepare vegetables steamed, stir-fried, or grilled. Each method preserves nutrients differently, so vary your approach across the weeks.

Ingredient	What it offers
Spinach	Iron, calcium, magnesium, and Vitamins A, C, and K in one leaf. Builds blood, supports bone health, and alkalises the body. Cook lightly to preserve its nutrients.
Imfino (wild greens)	One of the most nutritionally dense foods in the South African diet. Rich in iron, calcium, and folate. Soak in salt water for 10 to 15 minutes before washing and preparing. Free, local, and more powerful than most supplements.
Cabbage	A natural gut healer, high in Vitamin C and glutamine, which repairs the intestinal lining. Fermented, it becomes sauerkraut, one of the most effective probiotic foods available.
Carrots	Beta-carotene for skin and eye health. Naturally sweet, they satisfy without spiking blood sugar when eaten as part of a full meal.
Butternut	Rich in Vitamins A and C, potassium, and fibre. Warming, grounding, and deeply nourishing. A comfort food that also heals.
Mushrooms	One of the few plant sources of Vitamin D. Supports the immune system and feeds beneficial gut bacteria. A quiet intelligence that science is only beginning to understand.

Healthy Fats

Ingredient	What it offers
Avocado	Monounsaturated fats that protect the heart, support fat-soluble vitamin absorption, and nourish the skin from within. Half an avocado with a meal transforms it into medicine.
Olive oil	Anti-inflammatory and liver-supportive. Use cold or at low heat to preserve its properties.
Coconut oil	Contains medium-chain triglycerides used directly by the body for energy. Antimicrobial and gut-supportive. Use in cooking or add a small amount to meals.
Nuts	Concentrated protein, healthy fat, and minerals. A small handful is enough. The body does not need more.

Fermented Support

Ingredient	What it offers
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Sauerkraut	Fermented cabbage is one of the most potent probiotic foods available. Reseeds the gut with beneficial bacteria, supports digestion, and strengthens immune function. Introduce 1 tablespoon from Day 3 and continue daily throughout all four weeks. The full recipe is included free in the Alchemy of Nature collection at iamnature.co.za .
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Herbal Support

Ingredient	What it offers
Fenugreek	Regulates blood sugar, supports digestion, and helps reduce inflammation. Soak seeds overnight and drink the water first thing in the morning.
Fennel	Relaxes the digestive tract and relieves bloating. In traditional practice, associated with clarity of vision, both physical and intuitive.
Chamomile	Calms the nervous system, relaxes gut muscles, and supports deep, restorative sleep. One of the gentlest and most effective plant medicines available.
Mint	A natural digestive aid and decongestant. Clears the mind, freshens the body, and brings an immediate sense of lightness.
Moringa	One of the most nutrient-dense plants on earth. High in Vitamin C, iron, calcium, and potassium. Take as a tea on an empty stomach in the mornings, or add the powder to smoothies and porridge.

How it works

Daily structure

Each day follows the same simple rhythm. You are not counting calories or weighing portions. You are eating real food, at the right times, with the right rituals around it. The morning ritual is your anchor. Everything else is yours to choose freely from the food groups above. As a rough guide: a palm-sized portion of protein, a fist-sized portion of starch, and two handfuls of vegetables. Eat until satisfied, not full. Your body will tell you when it has enough.

Morning ritual: Choose one: fenugreek and fennel tea, warm lemon water, or moringa tea. All can be taken on an empty stomach. This is your first act of intention for the day.

Hydration: Living Water Elixir throughout the day. Sip consistently rather than in large amounts at once.

Main meal (12pm to 3pm): One protein, one starch, two vegetables, and a healthy fat. This is your one full meal. Eat slowly. Eat with awareness. All proteins, starches, and vegetables in this plan are freely interchangeable.

Optional snack: A small handful of nuts or one piece of fruit if genuinely hungry. Not out of habit.

Daily broth: One cup daily. Choose one: chicken or bone broth for collagen support, skin elasticity, and deeper nourishment; or vegetable broth for detox support, minerals, and plant-based nourishment. For deeper skin repair and elasticity, bone broth is recommended where possible. Vegetable broth remains a powerful alternative that supports the body's natural healing processes.

Evening: Herbal tea or a light smoothie. Keep the evenings light and allow the body to rest and repair. In the first week especially, if the light evening feels too significant a shift, a small cup of warm vegetable broth or a light vegetable soup is a good transition option.

Evening options

Evenings are a time to slow the body down. You may choose your evening drink based on how you feel.

Herbal teas:

- Chamomile
- Lavender
- Peppermint or mint
- Hibiscus
- Fennel
- Ginger

Or on some evenings:

- A light smoothie
- Warm broth

Keep evenings light and calming.

WHY NOON? EATING WITH THE SUN

Ancient peoples across Africa, Asia, and the Mediterranean ate their primary meal at peak sun. They believed, and traditional medicine across many cultures confirms, that the body's digestive fire is at its strongest at noon. This is what it means to eat with the sun: to align your body's rhythms with the rhythms of the earth. Not because a programme says to, but because your body was designed to receive food at that time.

What I personally experienced

- Increased awareness and intuition throughout the day
- Better alignment of feminine and masculine energy within myself
- A stronger connection with the earth and with my own sense of self
- Improved overall health across every system
- Complete elimination of seasonal flu. Before this practice, I was ill four times a year. Since beginning, none.
- No more frequent headaches, which had been a recurring pattern for years
- Sustained, natural energy without the crashes that come from eating too frequently
- A lighter body feeling, not just physically but in how I moved through the world

This is not a theory. It is what I lived. Your experience will be your own, but the pattern tends to hold: when you eat with the sun, the body wakes up.

The four phases

Week 1: Adaptation · Week 2: Balancing · Week 3: Acceleration · Week 4: Consistency

The anchor recipes

These are the core preparations used throughout the four weeks. They are included here so that you can begin Day 1 without needing anything else. The full Alchemy of Nature recipe collection, with 35 preparations across seven healing categories, is available at iamnature.co.za.

Morning Ritual Tea

Fenugreek and Fennel

Ingredients

- 1 tsp fennel seeds, lightly crushed
- 1/2 tsp fenugreek seeds
- 500ml water at approximately 90°C
- Raw honey to taste (optional)
- A few drops of lemon (optional)

Method

1. Lightly crush seeds with a spoon or mortar.
2. Heat water to just below boiling.
3. Add seeds and steep uncovered for 10 minutes.
4. Strain and add honey if using. Drink warm on an empty stomach.

Living Water Elixir

Daily Hydration

Ingredients

- 1/2 cucumber, thinly sliced
- Juice of 1 lemon
- 1 tbsp chia seeds
- Pinch of Himalayan salt, Celtic salt, or sea salt
- 1 litre filtered water

Method

5. Combine all ingredients in a jug or bottle.

6. Stir well and leave to infuse for at least 30 minutes.
7. Stir again before drinking. Sip consistently throughout the day.

Blood Builder Smoothie

Energy and Iron Support

Ingredients

- 1 medium beetroot, peeled and chopped
- 1 ripe banana
- 6 Medjool dates, pitted
- 2 large handfuls baby spinach
- 300ml water or coconut water
- Juice of half a lemon
- Pinch of ground cinnamon

Method

8. Add liquid to blender first, then soft ingredients, beetroot last.
9. Blend on high for 60 to 90 seconds until completely smooth.
10. Add lemon juice and blend briefly. Drink within 20 minutes of making.

Hormone Balance Smoothie

Energy and Hormonal Support

Ingredients

- 1 ripe banana
- 1 tbsp ground flax seeds
- 1/2 tsp Ceylon cinnamon
- 250ml oat milk or coconut milk
- 1 tsp raw honey

Method

11. Add all ingredients to blender.
12. Blend until smooth. Drink in the morning.
13. Use ground flax seeds only. Whole seeds pass through undigested.

Evening Surrender Tea

Rest and Nervous System

Ingredients

- 2 tsp dried chamomile flowers or 1 tea bag
- 4 to 5 fresh mint leaves or 1/2 tsp dried
- 350ml just-boiled water
- 1 tsp raw honey
- Thin slice of fresh ginger (optional)

Method

14. Place chamomile, mint, and ginger in a cup.
15. Pour water just off the boil.
16. Cover and steep for 7 minutes.
17. Strain. Add honey after straining. Drink 30 minutes before bed.

Golden Immune Tea

Immunity Support

Ingredients

- 1 inch fresh ginger, sliced thin
- 1/2 tsp turmeric powder
- Juice of half a lemon
- 1 tsp raw honey
- Pinch of black pepper
- 350ml water

Method

18. Simmer ginger in water for 10 minutes.
19. Remove from heat. Add turmeric and black pepper.
20. Steep 5 more minutes. Strain.
21. Add lemon juice and honey. Drink warm.

Warm Vegetable Broth Daily Nourishment

Ingredients

- 1 litre filtered water
- 2 carrots, roughly chopped
- 2 sticks of celery
- 1 onion, halved

- 3 garlic cloves, crushed
- A handful of fresh or dried herbs: thyme, parsley, or bay leaf
- Salt to taste. A drizzle of olive oil (optional).

Method

Place all vegetables and herbs in a large pot. Cover with water and bring to a boil.

Reduce heat and simmer for 45 minutes to one hour.

Strain through a sieve and discard the vegetables. Season with salt. Drink warm, or use as a base for soups and stews. Store in the fridge for up to four days.

For deeper skin repair and elasticity, bone broth is recommended where possible. Simmer chicken bones with apple cider vinegar, garlic, and herbs for four to six hours. Vegetable broth remains a powerful alternative that supports the body's natural healing processes.

WEEK 1

Adaptation

Your body is learning a new rhythm. Keep things simple. Be gentle with yourself. Notice everything.

All recipes referenced in this plan appear on the preceding pages.

Days	Main Meal (12pm-3pm)	Evening	Notes
Days 1-2	Boiled eggs, sweet potato, spinach or imfino, avocado, steamed cabbage	Chamomile or mint tea	Balanced start. Protein, starch, greens, and fat.
Days 3-4	Chicken stew, butternut, cabbage. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Herbal tea or light smoothie	First meat inclusion. Supports fullness and strength.
Days 5-6	Lentils, sorghum, tomato and onion salad, add avocado or oil. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Chamomile tea or broth	Plant-based protein day. Add fat for fullness.
Day 7	Mushrooms, sweet potato, steamed greens. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Light smoothie or broth	Lighter day. Supports digestion and resets.

"The body does not lie. It reflects exactly what is happening within."

WEEK 2

Balancing

Energy levels are steadying. Sleep is improving. This week, you begin to feel the difference.

Days	Main Meal (12pm-3pm)	Evening	Notes
Days 8-9	Grilled chicken, sorghum, vegetables. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Chamomile or lavender tea	Protein supports sustained energy.
Days 10-11	Eggs, avocado, mushrooms. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Herbal tea	Simple and satisfying. Easy digestion.
Days 12-13	Beans, sweet potato, spinach or imfino, add oil. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Chamomile tea or broth	Fibre-rich. Supports gut health.
Day 14	Mince or soya mince, cabbage, carrots. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Light smoothie or tea	Heavier meal. Observe how your body feels.

"Consistency is not perfection. It is simply showing up, again and again, for yourself."

WEEK 3

Acceleration

The body is now working with you. Digestion is clearer. Skin may begin to shift. Pay attention.

Days	Main Meal (12pm-3pm)	Evening	Notes
Days 15-16	Chicken, avocado, fresh salad. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Chamomile tea	Light but nourishing. Good balance.
Days 17-18	Lentils, sorghum, greens, add oil. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Herbal tea or broth	Steady energy. Supports digestion.
Days 19-20	Eggs, mushrooms, butternut. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Tea	Simple and consistent.
Day 21	Beans, sweet potato, spinach or imfino. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Tea or broth	Grounding meal. End of week reflection.

"What you cannot force, you can sometimes simply outgrow."

WEEK 4

Consistency

This is the medicine now. Repeat what works. Your body knows the rhythm. Trust it.

Days	Main Meal (12pm-3pm)	Evening	Notes
Days 22-23	Chicken, sweet potato, greens. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Chamomile or lavender tea	Familiar rhythm. Body is adapting.
Days 24-25	Eggs, avocado, salad of your choice	Herbal tea	Light and balanced.
Days 26-27	Lentils, vegetables, add oil. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Tea or broth	Keep it simple. Notice preferences.
Days 28-30	Fish with sorghum and cabbage OR mushrooms with butternut and greens. Add 1 tbsp sauerkraut on the side.	Tea or light smoothie	Final days. Choose what feels right.

"This is the medicine now. Repeat what works. Trust the process."

The inner shift

As the body begins to clear and stabilise, something else may begin to shift quietly. I noticed clearer thinking, deeper sleep, more vivid dreams, a stronger sense of intuition, and an increased awareness of how different foods affect me.

This is not something to force or chase. It is something to notice.

When the body is no longer overwhelmed, it becomes easier to hear what it is communicating, not only physically, but internally. Pay attention to your thoughts, your emotional responses, your dreams, and your natural preferences. You may find that your body begins to guide you away from certain foods and toward others without effort.

Grounded understanding

As you simplify what you eat and reduce highly processed foods, your body begins to regulate digestion, energy, and appetite more efficiently. At the same time, you may experience increased mental clarity and awareness.

You do not need to define this. You only need to observe what happens to you.

The work is not to control the body. The work is to listen.

You have arrived

You have returned

This is not the end of a programme. It is the beginning of a different relationship with your body.

You do not need to force discipline anymore. Your body now participates in the decision.

You are no longer trying to control yourself. You are learning to listen.

Thirty days is a beginning, not an endpoint. Carry forward what served you. Notice what your body now asks for naturally. Trust that knowing. It is not willpower. It is the result of 30 days of listening.

The recipes in the Alchemy of Nature collection are there to support you as you continue. The full botanical library at iamnature.co.za holds the deeper wisdom of the plants that accompanied you through this reset.

You chose yourself. Your body followed.

YOU ARE NATURE.

iamnature.co.za

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